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A NEW 'HANGOUT' IN SANTHOME

Greater Chennai Corporation's gym at 4th Trust Link Street promises to draw many fitness enthusiasts, for sure teachers from a neighbouring school **P2**



JUDGE A PURCHASE BY ITS COVER

From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible **P6**

PHOTO. RAGU R

The absence of traffic police personnel during the evening hours at this three-road intersection is keenly felt; the presence of four schools in the vicinity is also felt at this time of day



such traffic.

In the same breath, he notes the absence of these personnel is felt in the evening rush hour, particularly around school closing time.

Because of lack of regulation, motorists hitting the junction are a law unto themselves and the unruliness creates a conducive climate for accidents.

Besides ensuring traffic police personnel show up at the junction in the evening, efforts also need to be made to discuss school-closing time with these schools. If these schools put their heads together with arrive at different school-closing time, traffic from them would not hit the junction *en masse*.

He underlines another factor contributing to the traffic chaos at the junction: lack of parking at a marriage hall at Avvai Shanmugam Salai causes unauthorised parking.

Gopalapuram junction lacks 'overseers' at crucial hour

R. RAGU

Avvai Shanmugam Salai and Conran Smith Road and Gopalapuram First Street concentrate traffic at a junction in Gopalapuram. Around this junction, school bells ring more often than vehicle horns are hooted.

Four schools (DAV Boys Senior Secondary School, DAV Girls Senior Secondary School, National Public School and Sunshine C. Sarda Secondary School) nestle nearby.

In the morning hours, traffic police personnel are in attendance before school students are, at their respective schools; and that ensures regular motorists have a smooth run through the junction, unaffected by the



hurly burly of parents and their wards in tow descending on the junction with their wheels. The personnel in white-and-khaki regulate traffic around school time and prevent logjams. Residents seek the same diligence from the traffic police in the evening when the schools close for the day.

B. Bhaskaran, a Gopalapuram resident, notes that this junction is under greater strain ever since the

Royapettah High Road-Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai flyover (also called 'Ajantha bridge') was demolished and additional traffic began to flow through Gopalapuram First Street and the junction on the way to destinations such as Peters Road, Royapettah GH and Pycrofts Road.

Bhaskaran observes that the presence of traffic police personnel ensures the junction is not overwhelmed on account of school as well as

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A new 'hangout' in Santhome



Greater Chennai Corporation's gym for women at 4th Trust Link Street promises to draw many fitness enthusiasts, for sure teachers of a neighbouring school

M. SRINATH

On Fourth Trust Link Street at Santhome in Mylapore, a piece of vacant land cheek by jowl with a Greater Chennai Corporation-run middle school was being arm-twisted every day into functioning as a garbage dumping spot by residents and passersby.

That piece of land belonging to GCC



The gym is open from 6 a.m. to 10 a.m. and 4 p.m. to 8 p.m. PHOTOS: M. SRINATH

now finds its hand strengthened having been made part of an arrangement that gets people to "twist" their bodies for their own good. GCC has established a modern women gym's at a cost of ₹80 lakh, which was drawn from the Mayor's fund as well as the Councillor's Fund. Found in Ward 126, the gym was inaugurated by Mylapore MLA P. Venkataramanan on July 8, 2026. Councillor of Ward 126 Amirtha Varshini was present.

The gym is around 200 metres from Santhome High Road (the point of the road where the old registrar office was located) and this would be among factors encouraging greater patronage.

The timings of the gym have been drawn up in a manner that would benefit both working women who need to get their daily dozen before leaving for work in the morning and homemakers who would be strapped for time in the early hours having to attend to family members heading to school/ college and office. The gym is open at the following time periods: 6 a.m. to 10 a.m. and 4 p.m. to 8 p.m. There is a sentiment that the morning session can be extended by an hour or two making it even more convenient for homemakers who can stroll in conveniently after completion of household chores.

The person in-charge, B. Thangam, is hugely flexible, being prepared to keep the gym doors open for a while outside the stipulated hours if doing so would help someone.

At the time *The Hindu* visited the gym, Geetha Lakshmi, a teacher at the Corporation school in the compound, was working out in the gym. She observes, "The place where the gym stands now had gone to seed. Raising a gym there is the best thing to have happened to the place, residents and habitués of the area. For the last two days that the gym has been open, teachers from this school have been dropping in for workout, after school hours. Having this facility next door is a great convenience."

Felci Therese, a resident of the area, notes that all the other gyms in the area being paid facilities, the Corporation gym is a boon to the neighbourhood.

Says Vanitha R., a resident of Santhome: "At this gym, there are dedicated weight training and strength sections, 8-10 cardio machines including treadmills, cycles, ellipticals, plus dumbbells, twisters, and training benches. There are yoga mats for terrace and outdoor yoga – a rare touch that encourages holistic wellness."

Handicraft expo at Egmore Museum campus

The Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar) is having a handicraft exhibition till July 19 at Government Museum campus in Egmore.

Aimed to promote handicraft heritage, the event provides a common platform for artisans from various states to market their products

directly to the public, said a release.

From bronze icons to brass traditional lamps, Thanjavur paintings, art plates, papier mache dolls, bamboo crafts, wood carvings, stone sculptures, clay and terracotta products, cane furniture, jute products, fashion jewellery, incense and perfumery, there's a lot to choose from. Purchasing traditional handcraft-

ed products from artisans will support the livelihoods of artisans and craft communities while preserving India's rich artistic and cultural heritage, the release added.

The expo was inaugurated on July 7 by P. Mathan Raja, Minister for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises.

T. N. Venkatesh, Principal Secretary, Government of Tamil Nadu, Handlooms, Handicrafts, Textiles, and Khadi Department, and S. Amirtha Joshi, Managing Director, Tamil Nadu Handicrafts Development Corporation Limited (Poompuhar), participated.



Declare South Mada Street a 'no parking' zone

SONY

Traffic congestion along with safety of pedestrians on South Mada Street in Mylapore is a matter of concern. This vital stretch, which leads to the historic Kapaleeshwarar Temple, has become nearly impassable for pedestrians, especially senior citizens.

The primary cause of this chaos is the blatant encroachment of footpaths by shop vendors on both sides of the street. Because vendors completely occupy the platforms, pedestrians are forced to walk on the busy road. This danger is multiplied by haphazard vehicle parking and unregulated traffic flow. Senior ci-



FILE PHOTO

tizens, who visit the temple every day, face immense difficulty navigating this chaotic stretch and are highly vulnerable to accidents.

To restore order and ensure safety, the authorities concerned must take the following steps:

Clear all illegal platform encroachments to give footpaths back to pedestrians.

Declare South Mada Street a strict "No Parking" zone or designate specific, regulated parking slots.

Deploy traffic police personnel during peak hours to manage vehicle movement.

Consider making the street a pedestrian-only zone during festival days and weekends.

The writer is a resident of Venkatesha Agrharam, Mylapore

You can be our volunteer-writer

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number



'Take a closer look at road milling'



SUJATHA VIJAYARAGHAVAN

With reference to the article 'Chitrakulam North Street under the scanner' in *The Hindu Downtown* article dated July 5, I would like to share our experience in Alwarpet that gets flooded, as the roads have risen above the level of the houses. In the last 25 years, the height of many roads in Alwarpet, including Murray's Gate Road, has risen by nearly two and a half feet. A heavy shower for two hours brings water into our compounds and houses.

Ever since road laying became easy with the machine laying a whole road in four hours in the night, the Corporation has gone on a road laying spree. Road laying is a lucrative proposition for all concerned. The victims are the public.

Milling of roads is an eye-

wash, as the surface is barely scratched for 1.5 inches and the level raised by 6 to 8 inches in one laying. Manhole concrete rings are piled one on top of the other to make the manhole cover level with the newly laid road. In our area 9 concrete rings have been stacked one on top of the other in every manhole. The height of the nine rings is more than 4 feet and it shows how many times the road level has been raised in the last 25 years.

Raising road levels means pavements need to be raised and storm water drains need to be built, as all the rainwater needs to be drained only through SWDs. Gone are the days when water flowed on the roads and reached the nearest canal by gravity.

A warning sign is the arrival of new business ventures for providing gates for houses and buildings to stop the

flood and raising the houses from the foundation. These come at a whopping cost.

We have met every Commissioner of Corporation over the last 20 years with repeated requests to lower the roads. The only Commissioner who readily agreed to do so, subsequently never visited our area to inspect and stopped responding to our appeals.

A high level enquiry into the phenomenon of rising road levels is the urgent need to save the city and the citizens.

Lowering road levels is the only way to prevent flooding. In advanced countries roads are laid without raising the level by an inch. Our Corporation needs to learn the technique and introduce it in our city.

Sujatha Vijayaraghavan is a member of Venus Civic Ex-nora

Inner Beach Road gets 'wider'

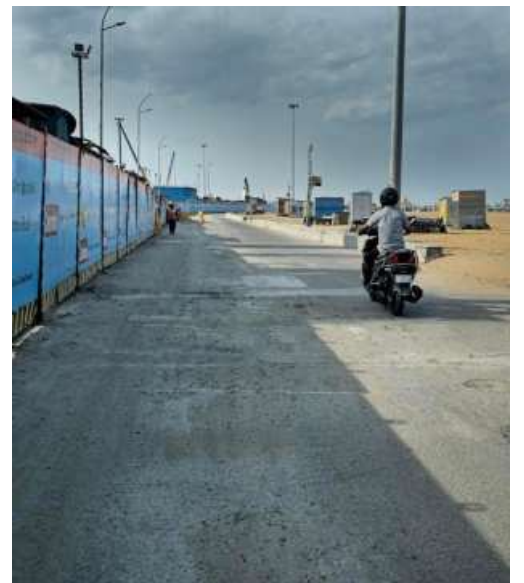
R. KASIM RAZVI

The stretch of inner Beach Road from Lighthouse to Vivekanandar Illam, which had been become narrow due to placement of metro construction barricades, did cause a lot of inconvenience to pedestrians and motorists.

With a major portion of metro construction now completed, metro rail authorities have removed the barricades from the completed sections, creating additional space for pedestrian movement, public convenience, and vehicle parking.

The remaining barricades have been shifted closer to the active metro construction site, reducing inconvenience to road users.

R. Kasim Razvi is a resident of Srinivasa Road in Mylapore



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Charging needs sharing



While an EV charging point for each parking lot at a gated community is a desirable ideal, practicality calls for shared infrastructure

LIFFY THOMAS

Data engineer Kiruba Joy's search for a reliable EV charging facility in a gated community remains elusive. Three years ago, when the resident association at the 300-unit apartment community in Porur, where Kiruba owns a flat, refused to facilitate a separate connection for him to charge his electric car, he shifted to a rented accommodation in Kolathur.

Now a resident of Paniyur near Uthandi, for the last nine months Kiruba has been visiting various apartment communities in South Chennai to invest in a flat that comes with a separate charging infrastructure for every parking lot. The hunt has been frustrating.

"After the State Government brought a notification in October 2025 that buildings with more than 50 dwelling units should provide fast charging points, I took it up with my association but they refused citing a safety issue," says Kiruba.

At his current home, he has a 20 meter wire running from the second floor of his flat's AC point to the parking area. As there are only six homes and no other tenant with an EV vehicle, Kiruba got consent from the other residents.

A gazette notification dated October 31, 2025 by the Housing and Urban Development Department of Tamil Nadu issued amendments to the Tamil Nadu Combined Development and Building Rules, 2019. It asks residential communities to provide a charging point for electric vehicles at every car and two-wheeler parking space. In buildings where the number of dwelling units exceeds 50, car and two-wheeler parking space earmarked for visitors shall be provided with fast charging points.

Many apartment associations *The Hindu Downtown* spoke note they are physical and technical challenges in getting even a basic common charging infrastructure, let alone a separate charging point for every parking lot. While many apartment associations discourage individuals from connecting their vehicles to their own meter, some allow it at the individual's risk.

Christopher M.P., a resident of a 120-

unit apartment in Thiru-Vi-Ka Nagar, Perambur, has a wire running from the third floor of his flat to the parking area where his electric two-wheeler is parked.

"Currently we have 6 electric vehicles in our community and the association was considering putting up a common charging point, but the vendor came up with the condition that even outsiders should be allowed to use the facility, which was not accepted, so we continue with this arrangement," says Christopher.

Many users like Kiruba who have switched to EV to reduce the budget on their fuel bills feel having just one or two charging points does not serve the purpose.

"For instance, it takes eight hours to charge my car and if there are even half-a-dozen EV cars in the community so you need an ample number of charging points," says Kiruba. He adds, "Charging from my home is cheaper than doing so at a common point as the latter involves a commercial rate and a fee for the vendor and association. So I am now looking for a community that also offers solar so my electricity bill would reduce drastically."

CREDAI's stand

After the State Government notification, the Confederation of Real Estate Developers' Association of India - Chennai sent a letter to the Additional Chief Secretary, Housing and Urban Development Department in November 2025, stating that it is not possible to provide individual charging infrastructure even in their upcoming projects.

"The requirement of a one-to-one charger-to-parking ratio may be technically unnecessary, financially burdensome, and operationally impractical, especially in large residential developments," reads the letter signed by A. Mohamed Ali, president, CREDAI- Chennai.

The Confederation suggested that Tamil Nadu follow a progressive, scalable model that includes a minimum of three EV chargers for buildings with 10-75 parking slots; one charger per 25 parking slots thereafter; upgradation to one per 18 slots by 2030 and one per 15 slots by 2035; and mandatory trunking, ducting and electrical provisioning to double capacity when required.

99 and counting

Enduring gems

Even as Music Academy is on course to complete its hundredth year, three other enterprises, also born on Madras soil in 1927, are headed in the same direction. A salute to auction house Murray & Co, pen seller Gem & Co and timeless rose milk sensation Kalathi Shop for their endurance and uniqueness



Gem & Co at NSC Bose Road in George Town.

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

There are four parts to longevity in business. One part is ingenuity, and the other three are just plain, old-fashioned, boring stick-to-itiveness. Those four parts working in perfect synchronicity, seller of pens, a whopping number of them fountain pens, Gem & Co has continued at the same address on NSC Bose Road in George Town for no less than 99 years. As it is poised to complete 100 years of existence in February 2027, there are no signs it could be running out of ink.

M. Pratap Kumar, representing the third-generation at the reins of Gem & Co after grandfather M.C. Cunnann and father M. Prabhat Kumar, has had greater need for those three parts because of the times in which he is holding those reins. Pratap is penning Gem & Co's brand story challenging the digital onslaught as seen by the writing pad being increasingly replaced by the keyboard.

And then there are the mundane hiccups, the gremlins that play a nasty trick on you when you do not even suspect their existence. Having seen 64 summers, Pratap has had a share of these niggles, finding some of those summers tough, and some winters too, the latter indicated by the shop's increased height.

"We had to increase the height of the shop because of the water coming in during every rain as a result of the road level going up over the decades, and we had to

pump out the water or manually push it out," explains Pratap.

The overarching challenge however comes from the digital takeover of writing and the pervasive disposable, throwaway culture particularly pronounced where stationery is concerned. In 1927, when his grandfather M.C. Cunnann and business partner S. Venkatarangam Chetty were seeking to shift the focus of their business from general trade to one focussed on an exclusive product line, and the lot fell on fountain pens and Gem & Co as its known today was born, no hazy clouds of doubt hung over the decision. The clouds would not drift in for many decades to follow. Back then selling fountain pens was a sensible choice as children often went through the grades with the same fountain pen.

"Now , this business is not feasible, but we are still running it because of the passion we have for fountain pens. It is running in my blood," Pratap observes, sheer pride in the trade overriding everyday realities. "The profit is less; customers have become less." Pratap has steered the family business since 1985 and the enthusiasm for designing and selling fountain pens, particularly hand-crafted artisanal pens has not flagged. True to what its name is associated with, the Gama line of fountain pens made and marketed by Gem & Co remains "undefeated". It is named after the legendary undefeated pehalwani wrestler Ghulam Hussain Baksh Bhat (1878-1960) who went by the ring name "The Great Gama".

"My grandfather was a patriot and a freedom fighter; he wanted the pen to be named after an Indian hero," Pratap observes. "My grandfather would have thought

the pen would be as strong as the wrestler."

Pratap reveals that "the making of plastic moulded pens are outsourced to manufacturers elsewhere in India such as Mumbai. The ebonite, hand-crafted pens are made by us." Though remaining steadfast to its ebonite craftsmanship, the company has embraced the changing times by introducing models, vibrant acrylic and transparent demonstrator fountain pens among them, likely to appeal to the younger generations. The store also repairs fountain pens, restoring what are treasured possessions to their keepers and cannot be valued in purely materialistic terms.

Who actually keeps Gem & Co up and writing its long story?

Certainly not those like this reporter who was briefly drawn to a fountain pen just to have an experience close to that of a Victorian writer hunched over an unwritten page, a dip pen in hand, a lit candle on the table, and perhaps, a dramatic rumble of thunder disturbing the quiet. The patrons of Gem & Co are not drawn to

fountain pens on account of a fleeting excitement; they have written the use of fountain pens into their everyday script.

"We are able to sustain the business because of the generation that has been buying from us for 40, 50 and 60 years. But the customer base is not restricted to them. A steadfast customer, who is 92

years old, continues to buy from us, now for his grandchildren. People from those generations pass on the interest to their children and grandchildren, who head to our shop to buy fountain pens.

A 'rose' keeps blooming

Kalathi Shop at North Mada Street in Mylapore shuns the glare of public attention. Text requests for newspaper interviews can go unanswered. Considerable ink about Kalathi shop has been spilt on newsprint; and the novelty of press coverage has long worn off. Food bloggers and vloggers have offered it their share of glorification; there are enough bytes about Kalathi out there to sustain a 24-hour nonstop programming schedule on television. On Google, Kalathi shop manages an impressive 4.3 against 4,193 Reviews.

So much attention being showered on a petty shop, its limited dimensions and address unchanged since its inception in 1927, for what? A drink it fills a small rectangular pet bottle with. Its rose milk has captured generations of taste buds. It sells other items including newspapers, but reels in visitors from far and wide for its rose milk, and has consolidated a set of loyal followers far beyond Mylapore's radius.

For the last 15 years since he discovered this shop, Suresh Kumar. V., a resident of Valasaravakkam, has headed to North Mada Street many a time just to savour the chilled drink.

Many try to recreate the taste at home buying rose milk essence from Kalathi. Siji S., a resident of Nungambakkam, says she has experimented with Kalathi's rose milk essence several times. While she has come close, she admits she has never been able to plicate the exact taste.

Pratap seeks to present a proper measure of fountain pens, one shorn of the romance that goes with them. They are "economical, eco-friendly and remarkably durable"; he however, believes their value lies beyond practicality.

'Every transaction is special': Murray & co

Any popular music consumer who scours the decades for earworms would be familiar with the phrase "Hammer time", sung elegantly by M.C. Hammer in his "U Can't Touch This". In Madras and now Chennai, a different form of 'Hammer time' has been playing out since February 10, 1927 when Murray & Co saw the light. In the 99 years plus a few months of its existence, the auction house has not given that hammer a break except for a couple of times due to inescapable situations. What does the continuity mean to those at the helm of Murray & Co?

Hemant Srivatsa, partner, Murray & Co., responds: "We are very proud of it. We have conducted Sunday auctions almost without fail since our inception. There were a few weeks during our relocation when we had to pause, and of course, the pandemic was the longest period we could not hold auctions. Other than that, we have kept the tradition going."

Enterprises can dig their feet in, 'take over' a place by imprinting their character on it. And one cannot think of that place anymore without that enterprise popping up in the mind. And then enterprises take over people's mind space,

Since February 10, 1927, the hammer at this auction house has not had a break except for two seasons. The operational space has changed a few times, but its place in people's mind space has not



The team at Murray & Co

becoming a household name. Murray & Co has done both. After being identified with one space for a long time, a space behind the iconic LIC building on Mount Road, it has had to change addresses,

but its hold on the mind space of the city's residents has been unchanging and firm.

Hemant throws light on the addresses the auction house has had to its name.

"Our original auction room was located behind the LIC Building until 2012. We then briefly operated from Mandaveli before moving to our current premises at Gemini Towers, near the Gemini Flyover."

On how the business has evolved over the years, he observes: "We started with real estate auctions. From there, we expanded into retail auctions of household goods and furniture, followed by industrial auctions. There has always been a transition as the business adapted to changing times."

Hemant continues: "Within the retail space, the categories have changed significantly. We sell far more electronic items today than when I joined the business in 1992. The market has evolved, and so have the items."

Online auctions are becoming increasingly popular. Where does Murray & Co stand in cyberspace?

"Our industrial auctions are already completely online. Our retail auctions have not fully transitioned yet, though our online portal is currently being developed. Even after it is launched, we want to continue our physical auctions because they have a charm of their own that no technology can replace," says Hemant. And when prodded to name one transaction that has been hugely memorable for Murray & Co in the almost 100 years of its existence, Hemant refuses to take that route.

"Every single item is memorable. Every transaction is special, not just for us, but for the person who entrusted it to us and, hopefully, for the person who eventually bought it." Have grands plans been etched to celebrate the centenary when it arrives? "Yes, the plans are still in the works. Over the next few months, we will come up with concrete ideas to celebrate the centenary."

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A statement about mindful choices

Packaging doubles as a brand statement. A clothing label at Karpagam Gardens in Adyar, Tula India has dispensed with the branding part and instead made packaging a statement about mindful choices.

"We will ask customers to bring their own bags. Most of our customers do, and we'll also educate them," says Sushmitha R.K, designer at Tula India.

The approach begins well before a garment reaches the store. Cotton is transported in airtight plastic sacks that are reused year after year, while woven fabric moves between production units in reusable sack bags instead of new packaging. "So the cycle keeps repeating. Instead of buying new plastic covers every time and discarding them, we keep reusing what we already have," she says.

Garments are displayed without individual plastic covers. Customers are encouraged to bring their own bags, but those who forget are offered newspaper bags made by autistic adults using recycled newspapers or reusable cloth bags stitched from leftover organic cotton fabric. "Whatever big pieces of fabric are left after production, we make our cloth bags from them," says Sushmitha, adding that the bags are often pieced together from two or three fabric scraps.

The leftover fabric also serves another purpose. Larger parcels are wrapped in these fabric pieces, while smaller consignments are sent in paper envelopes.

Interestingly, the cloth bags are not sold despite customer demand. "Many people want to buy those bags because they like them. But we tell them the bag is not for sale. There's no purpose in buying another bag just to own it when you already have many bags at home," she says.

The store also uses conversations and posters to encourage customers to rethink disposable packaging.

For more information on Tula's approach to reducing unnecessary packaging, contact 8056163560 / www.tula.org.in

The bag bank

A cardboard box outside the entrance of Kazhani Native Farms in Kottivakkam has become an unlikely solution to a common retail problem. Instead of selling new carry bags, the farm invites customers to drop off extra shopping bags for others to reuse.

For Gokulnath Natesan, founder of Kazhani Native Farms, the idea stemmed from a growing dependence on packaging as the farm expanded its range of products. "As the product range increased, the

Aesthetically designed boxes, glossy wraps and branded bags often shape the way we purchase. But behind the appeal lies a growing question: how much packaging do we really need? From sharing unused bags to refusing unnecessary covers, these businesses in Chennai are finding ways to make packaging lighter, smarter and more responsible

Judge a purchase by its cover



Environment-friendly packaging and containers at Tula and Restore.

usage of packaging materials also increased," he says. "We realised that while we were conscious about sustainability and waste management, in another way we were increasing the usage of plastics."

Walk-in customers are encouraged to bring their own bags and containers, particularly for loose produce. For products such as juices and oils, customers are asked to return the same containers for refills. "We will fill it again and give it to you. Until it is good, you can use it instead of throwing it away," says Gokulnath.

The cardboard box outside the store extends the same idea. Customers leave behind extra carry

bags they no longer need, allowing others who arrive without one to reuse them.

"Instead of charging them, we told them they can take the bag. Similarly, if you have excess bags at home, you do not need to throw them away or keep filling your shelves. Just leave them here," he says. While home deliveries still rely on plastic packaging where alternatives prove impractical, Gokulnath says the reuse initiative has significantly reduced the farm's purchase of new carry bags.

"It has reduced our bag purchasing costs and plastics, and it has become a good habit for people," he says. "As others started dropping off excess covers, they also began

bringing other waste."

The farm now serves as a drop-off point for vegetable and garden waste, dry waste, e-waste and old garments. "The transaction does not end with the purchase," says Gokulnath. "It goes back as a message, creates awareness and builds an eco-friendly environment together."

For more information, contact @kazhani.in / Instagram - [@kazhanifarms](https://www.instagram.com/kazhanifarms)

Take a discount in your own bag

For most shoppers, the bag is an afterthought – a necessity con-

sidered only after the purchase is complete. At Restore on East Coast Road, Kottivakkam, it is the starting point of the shopping experience, where customers are encouraged to carry their own bags and rethink the way they approach packaging. Restore functions as the sister concern of Organic Farmers Market (OFM), an initiative built around connecting farmers directly with consumers. While both operate independently, they share a network of farmers and a common vision of creating a more community-driven approach to consumption.

Customers who walk in with their own bags or containers receive a 2% discount on groceries, a small gesture that encourages a larger change in the way people approach packaging.

According to Karthik R, General Manager, the idea is to make carrying reusable bags a natural part of the shopping routine. "We request customers

to bring their own bags and containers, especially for planned purchases like rice, grains and pulses," he says.

According to Karthik, although the discount is small, customers have responded positively to the initiative. Since nearly 70% of the revenue already goes back to farmers, the organisation cannot offer a larger discount.

However, he says the incentive has helped encourage more customers to adopt the practice. This practice has been part of Restore's approach for years. Plastic packaging has almost completely been eliminated from the store, with brown paper bags provided only when required. For products such as oils, customers are encouraged to bring their own containers, while glass bottles are available for those who need an alternative. But getting people to change a familiar habit has taken time. "In supermarkets, everything is packed and ready. People simply grab products and leave," says Karthik. "Asking customers to bring their own bags is a completely different paradigm."

He says the challenge is not the availability of alternatives, but the mindset around them. "People think minimal packaging is difficult or doesn't suit their lifestyle. But it's actually very easy," he says. "Customers tell us bringing their own containers simply becomes another item on their shopping checklist." There are, of course, practical hurdles. Paper bags can sometimes tear under heavier loads, requiring the store to constantly adapt its packaging methods. Yet, the focus remains unchanged.

For more information, contact @restore.org.in / Instagram - [@restoreorg](https://www.instagram.com/restoreorg)



Second generation Bharatanatyam *artistes honoured*

Performances by intellectually challenged and visually impaired artistes were among the other highlights of the event at Rukmini Arangam

Kala RASA Parampara Vaibhava, presented by RASA Arpita, concluded at Rukmini Arangam, celebrating 55 years of artistic excellence and 40 years of Natyacharya excellence of Ambika Kameshwar. The event honoured second-generation Bharatanatyam artistes carrying forward their gurus' artistic legacies while showcasing the transformative power of inclusive arts through moving performances by visually impaired and intellectually challenged artistes.

According to a release, the highlight of the celebration was the felicitation of distinguished second-generation Bharatanatyam artistes including Sukanya Ravindhar (Chitra Visweswaran's Chidambaram Academy of Performing Arts, Chennai), C. P. Satyajit (Bharata Kalanjali), and Aruna Rengasamy (Ramana Natyalaya). The honours celebrate artistes who uphold the Guru-Shishya Parampara and en-



Performance by visually challenged artistes and (below) the second generation artistes who were felicitated

Training visually challenged students requires extraordinary patience, dedication, and compassion

sure its continuity.

Anbu, a moving presentation by the visually challenged artistes of Shri Ramana Maharishi Academy for the Blind, Bengaluru, an outreach centre of RASA and the very first space where Ambika Kameshwar began her work with persons with special needs, and Margazhi Mahimai, a presentation by the RASA Stars, artistes with intellectual



Three new projects by **Kribha Housing**

Kribha Housing, a real estate development firm founded in 2021 by V. Ganesh and Krishna Ganesh, specialises in residential construction, remodeling and joint development projects across Chennai.

According to a release, V. Ganesh brings more than four decades of experience to the firm, having served as a partner at the Madhurams Group before founding Kribha Housing. The firm has constructed spaces in Chennai's most sought-after neighborhoods including Mylapore, Mandaveli, Alwarpet, Adyar, Besant Nagar, Thiruvannamiyur, T. Nagar, Madipakkam, and Gill Nagar. Kribha Housing currently has three projects underway – one in Mylapore, another in T. Nagar, and yet another one in Abhiramapuram.

For details, contact Krishna Ganesh at 89399 19277, V. Ganesh at 98410 73446. Email ID: kribhahousing@gmail.com.

A new beginning



Government Arts College in Nandanam held a 'Freshers Day' orientation programme on July 7. This year, around 800 students have enrolled in more than 10 courses offered by the college. A mental health awareness programme set the tone for the start of the new academic year. PHOTO: M. PRABHU

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▼ The batch; plants given to teachers and the 'enthu pataani' souvenir for alumnae; and cloth bag made with fabric bits. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND KANNAL ACHUTHAN

Green meets evergreen on college campus

The silver jubilee reunion of the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College offered an object lesson in sustainability, one that shut the door firmly on single-use plastics, use-and-throw culture and excess in celebration and opened the gates to composting of food waste, responsible consumption and green gifts

KANNAL ACHUTHAN

After the film 96, there is a pervasive trend of organising the silver jubilee reunion on a grand and memorable scale. 'Memorable' usually translates to adding extra layers to the celebration, sometimes making it extended to include a stop at a scenic location beyond the campus, say, a dinner at a resort. Rarely does 'memorable' mean paring the celebration to its bare minimum and make it meaningful, not just to the alumni but the wider world.

When they met for their 25th on their campus in Nungambakkam on July 10, the 2001 batch of Women's Christian College embraced the rarer version of "memorable", having the event guided largely by two factors, simplicity and ecological sustainability.

Saranya Palanichami, a readily recognised name in sustainability circles, being part of this batch,



one expected plastics to be shown the door. But the scale of the zero-waste consciousness she ushered in was beyond what was imagined.

"We did not have plastic water bottles or cups. Instead, we used steel tumblers for water and juice. No single-use cutlery. No printed invitations," notes Saranya.

Food waste was taken for

composting.

The alumnae got cloth bags made from fabric scrap from tailors and boutiques. These bits of cloth would have ended up in dumping grounds if not repurposed, she points out. Teachers, some of them now retired, received plants as mementos and winners of a fun quiz received

gift vouchers.

Spotlight on SDG 3

It was a "celebration" of Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) all the way. SDG 3, which is about health, was in bold relief, thanks to a panel discussion on navigating perimenopause. It made great sense as the alumnae are in their mid-forties.

Ardhra Ashokan, who travelled from the United States for the reunion, said that it was important for women to be able to reach out among their own network for support when going through this phase of life. "We need each other," she says, adding that the experts on the panel were drawn from the alumnae of WCC. Fitness and lifestyle coach Sheba Devaraj, clinical psychologist Debora Myrtle Anish of Stanley Medical College and Hospital and nutritionist-dietician Grace Gnana Priya dis-

cussed the importance of taking care of mind, body and soul. Sheba even did an onstage demo of the "inchworm workout", which requires no equipment and deploys one's own bodyweight for strength training.

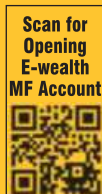
Gravitas and light-heartedness went hand in hand. After Susan George and group offered wonderful choral singing, the "madcap moments" started rolling. Going retro, the dancers of the batch performed to 'Mambo No. 5', the chemists in the batch donned lab coats to take a group photo and teachers sportively stepped in for a jive.

Jubilee Daniel and Sobana Laxmi took people down memory lane with their quiz. And when they asked what was the name of the mangy dog that lived on campus in 1999, pat came the answer. Nobody had forgotten Henry, one of the few males on campus.

Tamizh Theatre Festival from July 14

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan is conducting "Tamizh Theatre Festival 2026" consisting of four dramas from July 14 to July 17 at its main auditorium in Mylapore. The dramas will be staged every day at 6.45 p.m. On July 14: UAA presents Varadu Kutty-Paritchaikku Neramachu 2.; July 15 Three presents Kaatri-niley Varum Geetham; July 16, KNT presents Veera; July 17, TV Varadharajan and team presents Sangeetha Mumoorthigal.

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